

Music and dance



A boy plays a viol to accompany a lively dance, late 1500s

FROM THE ROYAL COURT to the peasant's cottage, music could be heard everywhere in Shakespeare's England. Many people played instruments, and, according to the 1588 book *In Praise of Music*, workers of all kinds kept up "a chanting and singing in their shops." When people went to see a play, they expected to hear good music. In Shakespeare's plays, there are more than 300 stage directions calling for

music. He used it to create atmosphere, just as it is used in films today. Trumpets and drums, for example, were played in battle scenes. Shakespeare also wrote more than 70 songs for his characters to sing.

A SPRING IN YOUR STEP

Many different dances were popular in Shakespeare's day. The galliard was a lively court dance with springing steps, leaps, and kicks, while the pavane was a stately dance, performed by a row of couples. Using long, gliding steps, ladies and gentlemen advanced, retreated, bowed, and curtsied. Away from court, people enjoyed less formal dances, such as the wild morris, danced with jangling bells strapped to the legs.



Couple dancing the galliard, by Flemish artist Hieronymus Francken the Elder, 1540–1610

Serenade in front of Silvia's window, by John Gilbert, c. 1860

LOVE SONG

In *Two Gentlemen of Verona*, Thurio, who is in love with Silvia, hires musicians to "give some evening music to her ear." They perform one of Shakespeare's many love songs, "Who is Silvia?" A piece of music performed beneath a woman's window in an attempt to win her love is known as a serenade.

SOUNDS FOR CLOWNS

The pipe and tabor were played at the same time by one person. The musician beat the tabor (drum) with one hand, while playing notes on the pipe with the other. The pipe and tabor were used to accompany jigs – the clowns' dances that were traditionally featured at the end of shows and plays.

ROYAL GIFT

This instrument was invented in 1580 by London instrument maker John Rose. He named it after Orpheus, a mythical ancient Greek musician. Rose is thought to have presented this, his first orpharion, to Queen Elizabeth I, who was an avid and skilled musician.



16th-century orpharion

